

10. Accept help

Some of your guests may have a special dessert or outstanding appetizer they would love to show off. You don't have to require a dish to attend, but if guests offer help and ideas, don't be shy about accepting. A few extra dishes that guests are happy to provide would help you a lot.

11. Allocate accordingly

Set a festive table and make sure you have plenty to offer guests, but you don't have to place everything you have on the table from the start. It's best for guests to take small portions and keep returning for more, rather than tempting them into grabbing more than they can finish.

12. Local access

If your home cannot accommodate the number of guests you'd like to have, consider facilities at a city park (some have indoor space for rent with great views and often include tables, chairs, and other equipment), community center, YMCA, or place of worship (generally available for free or discounted rates for members). Prices are *usually* much less expensive than meeting room space at a hotel, restaurant, or convention center.

— Julie Rains

8 Affordable Romantic Dates

Has budget dating become a real drag? Looking for ways to be really romantic while you're really broke? It's a challenge for married and unmarried couples alike. Here are eight easy ways to light a stylish spark without driving your budget into the ditch.

